Question Style Trends in Banking Exams 2026

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About this document

The banking exam syllabus has stayed largely the same, but the style and mix of questions has changed. This document summarises what candidates and analysts reported for the 2026 cycle, exam by exam, and what it means for practice.

Source note: the details below come from shift-wise exam analyses published by education sites after each exam, based on candidate feedback and memory-based recall, compiled on 9 October 2026. They are not official and can differ between shifts. Treat topic counts as approximate. Official patterns are in the Exam Pattern Guide.

Overall shifts seen across 2026 exams

1. Reasoning is dominated by puzzles and seating arrangements. In SBI PO Prelims about 25 of 30 reasoning questions were reported from puzzles, and syllogism and inequality were reported absent in the shifts reviewed.

2. Mains reasoning moved toward critical thinking: critical reasoning (assumption, strengthen, weaken, inference, conclusion), data sufficiency with two statements, decision making, cause and effect and machine input-output.

3. Quantitative aptitude relies on Data Interpretation (DI) and arithmetic word problems. Pure simplification and approximation appear less in PO Prelims but remain in clerk-level exams.

4. DI includes one-liner DI, line graph DI, table DI and caselet DI; in Mains, DI sets are long and calculation-heavy.

5. English leans toward contextual questions: cloze test, para jumbles, double fillers, word replacement and column-based questions, along with reading comprehension.

6. General awareness focuses on banking, economy and current affairs of roughly the last 6 months, including RBI circulars and digital and financial awareness.

7. Descriptive tests are typed online (SBI PO 30 marks, IBPS PO 25 marks).

SBI PO Prelims 2026 (1 and 2 August) - what was asked

SBI PO Prelims English Language (40 questions): reading comprehension on a photography exhibition theme, synonyms, about 5 to 6 para jumbles, 2 to 3 word replacement, 3 to 4 double fillers, 5 to 7 cloze test questions and error detection.

SBI PO Prelims Quantitative Aptitude (30 questions): arithmetic on boats, ages, trains, mensuration, averages, profit and loss, partnership and time and work; missing number series; mixtures. No approximation or simplification was reported in at least one shift. Difficulty was reported as easier than reasoning.

SBI PO Prelims Reasoning Ability (30 questions): about 25 puzzle questions, including a tricky selection-based puzzle with 11 persons and month-based puzzles with a variable; a few blood relation and number-based questions. Syllogism and inequality were not reported.

SBI PO Mains 2026 (12 September) - what was asked

SBI PO Mains was reported as moderate to difficult, with Data Analysis and Interpretation the toughest and most calculation-heavy section, and reasoning lengthy.

SBI PO Mains Reasoning and Computer Aptitude: about five major puzzles (month-date, floor with variables, circular, box, city-person table, linear and parallel-row seating); about 8 to 10 critical reasoning questions; 3 data sufficiency questions with two statements (floor based, parallel row and direction); and one question each on decision making, cause and effect and conclusion.

SBI PO Mains Data Analysis and Interpretation: several DI sets plus arithmetic, reported as tough. SBI PO Mains English: reading comprehension, cloze test, para jumbles, column-based questions and error detection, at moderate difficulty.

SBI PO Mains General, Economy and Banking Awareness: banking and economic current affairs. SBI PO Mains descriptive: typed tasks such as writing an email to HR declining a job offer.

IBPS PO Prelims 2026 (22 and 23 August) - what was asked

IBPS PO Prelims was reported as moderate overall. Reasoning had puzzle and seating sets (about five sets in one shift) along with miscellaneous topics such as syllogism, inequality, coding-decoding, blood relations and direction sense.

IBPS PO Prelims Quantitative Aptitude: DI sets were simple one-liners, line graph DI and table DI; number series, DI and arithmetic were common; in one shift there were no simplification, missing number series or quadratic equation questions. English was easy to moderate.

Reported good attempts for IBPS PO Prelims Shift 1: about 65 to 72 overall, with 23 to 26 in English, 18 to 21 in Quantitative Aptitude and 22 to 25 in Reasoning.

IBPS PO Mains 2026 (4 October) - what was asked

IBPS PO Mains had a revised pattern. Reasoning included puzzles, seating arrangements, critical reasoning (strengthening, assumptions, arguments, weakening, inference and conclusion), machine input-output, syllogism and data sufficiency.

IBPS PO Mains Data Analysis and Interpretation: DI, number series, quadratic equations, data sufficiency and arithmetic; reports mention five DI sets, arithmetic word problems and a miscellaneous section, with lengthy paragraph-based questions that took time.

IBPS PO Mains General, Economy, Banking, Digital and Financial Awareness: most questions reported from July to September 2026 current affairs and RBI circulars.

IBPS PO Mains reported good-attempt ranges by section (one source): Reasoning 15 to 20, General Awareness 16 to 20, English 22 to 25, Data Analysis and Interpretation 12 to 16.

SBI Clerk Prelims 2026 (26 and 27 September) - what was asked

SBI Clerk Prelims was easy to moderate across shifts.

SBI Clerk Prelims Reasoning Ability: puzzles (about 10 questions in one reported shift), standard seating arrangements, week-based puzzles, alphanumeric series, blood relations, inequality, syllogism and Chinese coding (about 5 questions in one shift). Topics reported absent in one shift: unascertained linear arrangement, flat and floor puzzles, year-based and stack-based puzzles and direction and distance.

SBI Clerk Prelims Numerical Ability: speed mathematics and direct DI as the main weight (including caselet DI), simplification, number series, quadratic equations, and direct single-concept arithmetic.

SBI Clerk Prelims English Language: reading comprehension, contextual vocabulary, para jumbles, fillers, error detection and core grammar, at an easy to moderate level.

Reported good-attempt ranges for SBI Clerk Prelims: Reasoning 28 to 32, Numerical Ability 25 to 28, English 21 to 27.

IBPS Clerk, IBPS RRB and RBI Assistant

Detailed 2026 shift analyses for IBPS Clerk, IBPS RRB and RBI Assistant question styles were not reviewed for this document. The SBI Clerk trends above are the closest guide for clerk-level Prelims, since all use the same three-section style (English, numerical ability, reasoning). The RBI Assistant Prelims was held in April 2026; its General Awareness in Mains emphasises banking, economy and RBI topics.

What this means for practice

Spend more reasoning time on puzzles: practise linear, circular, floor, month-based and box puzzles, and learn when to skip a long set.

For Mains, add critical reasoning and data sufficiency to daily practice, and practise DI sets under a timer, because DI is the most calculation-heavy part.

In Quantitative Aptitude practise comparison-style questions, number series, quadratic equations and short arithmetic word problems rather than only formula drills.

In English practise cloze tests, para jumbles, word replacement and double fillers with a timer, and keep descriptive writing practice typed, not handwritten.

Revise current affairs of the last 6 months along with RBI policy updates such as the October 2026 repo rate decision (see Banking Awareness).